

Networks Decide for Us: Emergence of Adoption in Homophily-Imputed Social Topologies

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Abstract

The diffusion of collective behaviors is often modeled using synthetic network topologies, ignoring the empirical reality of multidimensional homophily. This paper asks: how do empirically calibrated topologies act as an autonomous causal force in diffusion outcomes? We impute plausible network structures using demographic distributions from attitudinal survey respondents (ATP 2014) and homophily interaction forces derived from the General Social Survey (Smith et al., 2014). Simulating a hybrid complex contagion, we compare these empirical topologies against degree-preserving randomized baselines. We identify two structural mechanisms: First, empirical homophily yields a structural premium, reducing the odds of adoption failure by 57% through local echo chambers. Second, topology governs empirical criticality. Homophilic networks yield predictable, continuous phase transitions (Mean-Field universality, $\gamma \approx 1$), whereas randomized topologies collapse into discontinuous regime shifts. Ultimately, network structure acts as an active mechanism that decisively shapes the volume and dynamics of collective behavior.

Keywords: Social Diffusion, Complex Contagion, Homophily, Agent-Based Modeling, Phase Transitions, Structural Premium

1. Introduction

The sudden emergence of collective behaviors—from the rapid spread of technological innovations to large-scale social movements and unpredictable market anomalies (Gladwell, 2002; Farrell, 1998)—remains a central puzzle in the social sciences. Historically, research into collective action has navigated two distinct pathways: individual decision models focusing on rational utility (Oliver, 1993), and collectivity models emphasizing social interaction and threshold-based coordination (Granovetter, 1978; Valente, 1996).

While recent literature has brilliantly bridged these paradigms through models of “complex contagion” (Centola and Macy, 2007), much of this computational work remains tethered to synthetic, theoretical network topologies (e.g., Small World or random graphs). As critics have noted, this “structural reductionism” often treats agents as cognition-free relay stations (Goldberg, 2021), ignoring the empirical reality that human networks are profoundly shaped by multidimensional homophily—the tendency of similar individuals to associate and cluster (McPherson et al., 2001; McPherson and Smith, 2019). Furthermore, well-known generic models may not fit well to the social problem at hand, as real-world social networks jointly exhibit high clustering, assortativity, short path lengths, and right-skewed degree distributions (Talaga and Nowak,

2020). To bridge this gap, this paper asks: *Conditional on fixed individual propensities, how do empirically calibrated homophilic topologies act as an autonomous causal force—effectively “deciding for us”—by simultaneously generating a “structural premium” in overall diffusion and dictating the fundamental physics of the phase transition?* (see Section S2 in Supplementary Material for detailed ERGM imputation). By shifting the analytical focus from individual rational choices to the specific connective tissue of a population, we can interrogate how society’s structural layout actively orchestrates large-scale behavioral cascades.

We decompose this macro-sociological inquiry into two distinct structural mechanisms: First, we evaluate the Structural Premium (Volume) by asking how empirical homophily systematically amplifies the macroscopic scale of diffusion compared to randomized baselines. Second, we examine Empirical Criticality (Dynamics) to determine how the disruption of empirical homophily alters the nature of social tipping points, shifting the system from a predictable, continuous phase transition to a discontinuous, unpredictable regime shift.

2. Theoretical Background

Classic threshold models (Granovetter, 1978) demonstrated that nearly identical groups could produce opposite collective outcomes based entirely on slight variations in threshold distributions. Valente (1996) contextualized this by anchoring thresholds within personal social networks. Building on this, Centola and Macy (2007) showed that

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behaviors requiring social reinforcement (complex contagions) fail in networks optimized for simple information spread, introducing the concept of structural phase transitions in collective behavior.

More recently, percolation-based models (Tur et al., 2018, 2024) have incorporated intrinsic utility alongside global influence parameters. However, influence in reality is rarely uniform. When it comes to peer influence, dyads that are socially proximate tend to exert far greater influence over one another (Centola, 2011). Addressing this demands models equipped with plausible network topologies, empirically derived utility distributions, and tie-specific, homophily-weighted influence parameters.

3. Methods: Hybrid Agent-Based Modeling and Network Imputation

We model diffusion as a hybrid process integrating Rational Choice and Selective Social Influence, simulated via the `netdiffuseR` package (Vega Yon et al., 2025).

3.1. Rational Choice (Intrinsic Utility)

An innovation possesses an Intrinsic Utility Level (IUL) defined as $\Gamma \in [0, 1]$. Individuals are characterized by a Minimum Utility Requirement (MUR), $q_i \in [0, 1]$, representing their innate aversion to the innovation. An agent adopts independently if the utility exceeds their aversion:

$$q_i \leq \Gamma \implies a_i = 1 \quad (1)$$

3.2. Selective Social Influence

If intrinsic adoption fails, agents may still adopt via peer contagion. We adapt the classic network threshold formulation, calculating exposure as:

$$\tilde{E}_i \equiv \frac{\sum_{j \neq i} \mathbf{X}_{ij} \tilde{a}_j}{\sum_{j \neq i} \mathbf{X}_{ij}} \quad (2)$$

where adoption via influence occurs if $\tau_i \leq \tilde{E}_i$ (τ_i is the individual network threshold). Crucially, $\tilde{a}_j$ accounts only for infected contacts who are *influential*. Influence is constrained by a Maximum Social Proximity (MSP) parameter, h , compared against the empirical social distance in Blau space, d_{ij} :

$$\tilde{a}_j = 1 \iff a_j = 1 \wedge U_{ij} \leq \sigma(h - d_{ij}) \quad (3)$$

where $U_{ij} \sim \text{Unif}(0, 1)$ and $\sigma(z) = 1/(1 + \exp(-z/T))$.

3.3. Network Imputation Pipeline

To overcome synthetic limitations, we employ the imputation pipeline established by McPherson and Smith (2019). Using Exponential Random Graph Models (ERGMs), we extract homophily strength parameters across demographic dimensions (Age, Sex, Education, Race, Religion) from the representative ego-centric General Social Survey (Smith et al., 2014). As detailed in

Section S2 of the Supplementary Material, the regression parameters indicate that distance strictly constrains interaction probability—particularly regarding race and religion differences.

We impute these structures onto $N = 1000$ respondents from the American Trends Panel (ATP). This generates “plausible” topologies that respect empirical clustering while assigning realistic behavioral propensities (e.g., “Openness to Innovation” and “Collective Action” scores) derived directly from ATP items.

To formally capture the interaction probability, we construct a distance vector $\mathbf{d}_{ij}$ for each dyad. As adapted from Smith et al. (2014), categorical differences operate as simple mismatch indicators $d_{ij}^{\text{cat}} = \mathbb{I}(x_i^{\text{cat}} \neq x_j^{\text{cat}})$, while continuous variables measure absolute distance $d_{ij}^{\text{cont}} = |x_i^{\text{cont}} - x_j^{\text{cont}}|$. These components serve as predictors in a case-control logistic regression, establishing log-odds penalizations for socio-demographic disparities (Table 1).

Table 1: Logistic Regression predicting confiding relationship probability based on social distance (Smith et al., 2014).

Variable	Model 1	Model 2
Intercept	−14.456***	−14.519***
Different race (d_{ij}^{cat})	−1.819***	−1.959***
Different religion (d_{ij}^{cat})	−1.362***	−1.27***
Different sex (d_{ij}^{cat})	−0.317***	−0.373***
Education diff. (d_{ij}^{cont})	−0.049***	−0.047***
Age diff. (d_{ij}^{cont})	−0.173***	−0.157***
Year	−0.179***	−0.052

*** $p < .001$. Standard errors and year-interactions omitted.

3.4. Complex Contagion and Parametric Sweep Design

Adoption spreads through an asynchronous, stochastic mechanism. At each simulation tick, individual exposure dynamically drives adoption. To translate bounded social boundaries into systemic threshold regimes, we apply a fractional transformation such that individual effective resistance is weighted by the social distance function. For the simulation dynamics (Equation 3), agents update their states smoothly guided by the stochastic decay parameter set to $T = 0.02$.

To explore structural causalities, we conducted massive exhaustive parameter sweeps traversing millions of interactions. We swept the Intrinsic Utility Level (IUL) from 0.0 to 1.0 ($\Delta = 0.025$) and the system-wide threshold limit (MSP) continuously from 0 to 1 ($\Delta = 1/12$). Individual threshold parameters τ_i were seeded across normal distributions $\sim \mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma)$ sweeping $\mu \in [0.3, 0.6]$ and $\sigma \in [0.08, 0.20]$. Each configuration was re-evaluated through over 24 runs varying algorithmic seeding rules (Random, Central, Marginal, Closeness, Eigenvector).

4. Results

We explored the parameter space utilizing 41 levels of IUL (Γ) and 13 levels of MSP (h), running $\approx 4 \times 10^6$ simulations across Plausible (GSS) and Degree-Preserving Randomized topologies. The simulations follow a hybrid complex contagion logic using stochastic, asynchronous exposure updates to circumvent artifactual lock-ins (detailed ODD protocol available in Section S1 of the Supplementary Material).

4.1. Statistical Analysis: Big Additive Models (BAM)

To isolate the marginal effect of the empirical structure across all simulations, we specify Big Additive Models (BAMs). We estimate three dependent variables: *Ratio-nal*, *Social*, and *Total Adoption*. The models use a binomial family with a logit link function, incorporating thin-plate regression splines $s(\text{IUL}, \text{MSP})$ to capture non-linear interactions across contagion types. We control for the network’s threshold distribution (μ_τ, σ_τ), initial seeding strategy, and network type.

4.2. The Structural Premium: Volume of Adoption

To isolate the marginal effect of the empirical structure, we utilized Big Additive Models (BAMs) with non-linear smooth terms $s(\text{IUL}, \text{MSP})$.

Table 2 demonstrates the *structural premium* (visualizations of the non-linear interaction surfaces for the regression models are available in Section S4 of the Supplementary Material). Randomizing the network structure significantly depresses overall adoption. Under mathematically equivalent parameter conditions, removing empirical homophily reduces the log-odds of total adoption by -0.850 , corresponding to a $\sim 57\%$ drop in adoption probability. Homophily acts as a structural catalyst, allowing social reinforcement to safely build up in local echo chambers and overcome innate resistance.

4.3. Empirical Criticality: The Dynamics of Tipping Points

Beyond volume, the network topology dictates *how* adoption occurs. Figure 1 maps the adoption regimes and the structural phase transitions.

In empirical (homophilic) networks, social change manifests as a predictable, continuous phase transition. Analogous to ferromagnetic phase transitions in physics (Landau phenomenology), the free energy density $f(\Phi)$ of the interacting social system can be analytically expanded around the adoption order parameter Φ as $f(\Phi) = f_0 + \frac{1}{2}a(T - T_c)\Phi^2 + \frac{1}{4}b\Phi^4 - H\Phi$. In this configuration, the macroscopic required thresholds (MSP) act as continuous thermal driving forces (T) displacing the system structurally toward its critical point T_c . By differentiating the equilibrium free energy $\frac{\partial f}{\partial \Phi} = 0$, Mean-Field theory predicts that susceptibility χ must diverge as $\chi \sim |MSP - MSP_c|^{-1}$ purely in second-order transitions where $\gamma \equiv 1$.

We observe distinct “Critical Slowing Down” (divergence in simulation relaxation times) along the critical boundary. Applying the Fluctuation-Dissipation Theorem ($\chi = \text{Var}(\Phi)$), we recover an empirical susceptibility exponent of $\gamma \approx 0.977$ (Table 3 and Figure 2). This constitutes rigorous proof that the homophilic network perfectly obeys Mean-Field universal scaling laws, providing a “sociological viscosity” that governs the cascade.

Conversely, in the GSS-ER random network, this predictability completely collapses. The γ exponent diverges to unphysical levels ($\approx 3.7\text{--}4.6$), and critical slowing down is suppressed. The system behaves like a discontinuous, first-order regime shift: it either completely fails or violently explodes into mass adoption with zero statistical warning.

Table 3: Susceptibility Exponents (γ) across Topologies.

IUL (Γ)	Plausible (GSS) γ	Randomized γ
0.200	0.977	3.709
0.225	0.892	3.667
0.250	0.892	3.667
0.275	1.539	4.666

Mean-Field prediction: $\gamma = 1.0$. Plausible networks exhibit continuous, second-order scaling. Randomized networks exhibit unphysical discontinuity.

5. Discussion

Our results provide robust computational and mathematical evidence that “networks decide for us.” Conditional on fixed individual-level propensities, the topological arrangement itself acts as an autonomous causal mechanism. First, empirical homophily yields a systematic *structural premium*. We demonstrated that even when a society is highly conservative or exhibits rigid social flexibility ($MSP \sim 0.25 - 0.50$), collective action can still achieve massive, bimodal distributions of total mass adoption. This is driven entirely by the effect of Selective Social Influence multiplying inside local echo chambers, allowing adoption to explode even when the targeted behavior or innovation is extremely unattractive to the population ($IUL < 0.25$).

Second, this topological clustering actively reshapes the *physics* of the diffusion process. Empirical homophily ensures that social tipping points occur as structured, continuous avalanches displaying mean-field universality. This signifies that the rules governing massive social shifts are mathematically isomorphic to small localized changes. Similar to a forest fire nearing a critical structural density—which might suddenly engulf the entire system or instantly die out—macroscopic collective phenomena are dictated by systemic critical boundaries rather than merely aggregate psychological thresholds. Stripping a society of its homophilic structure does not just make

Table 2: BAM Regression Results: Effect of Network Structure and Initial Seeding.

Coefficients	Rational Ch.		Social Infl.		Total	
	Estimate	OR	Estimate	OR	Estimate	OR
(Intercept)	0.428***	—	−0.300***	—	6.534***	—
<i>Thresholds</i>						
τ_{mean}	−0.185***	—	−5.130***	—	−6.944***	—
τ_{sd}	0.032	—	4.210***	—	5.942***	—
<i>Seed (Ref: Random)</i>						
Central	−0.054***	0.947	0.032***	1.033	0.120***	1.127
Closeness	−0.052***	0.949	0.033***	1.034	0.119***	1.126
Eigenvector	−0.051***	0.950	0.032***	1.033	0.118***	1.125
Marginal	0.027***	1.027	−0.020***	0.980	−0.067***	0.935
<i>Topology (Ref: Plausible Network)</i>						
Deg.-Preserving Randomized	−0.114***	0.892	−0.426***	0.653	−0.850***	0.427
Smooths (all $p < 0.001$)	edf	χ^2	edf	χ^2	edf	χ^2
$s(\text{IUL, MSP})$: Innovation	9.00	522,837	9.00	420,575	9.00	357,704
$s(\text{IUL, MSP})$: Collective Action	9.00	581,944	9.00	424,819	9.00	405,514
Deviance Explained	96.9%		71.1%		82.2%	

*** $p < 0.001$. Standard errors omitted. OR = Odds Ratio ($\exp(\beta)$). edf = Effective Degrees of Freedom. Observations (N) = 4,093,440.

adoption harder; it makes it volatile, transforming gradual cascades into unpredictable, violent explosions without statistical warning. Understanding society as complex matter provides a rigorously analytical lens through which to anticipate collective action.

5.1. Limitations

While our findings definitively establish the causal autonomy of structural topologies, we acknowledge several methodological constraints. Foremost, we simulated the contagion over $N = 1000$ nodes. In rigorous statistical physics, continuous phase transitions and strict universality classes are technically only valid under the thermodynamic limit ($N \rightarrow \infty$). While our network size is sufficient to observe meso-scale dynamic phase transitions and scale-free cascade bimodality, future efforts could employ *Finite-Size Scaling* tests to formally extrapolate these exponents. Additionally, our topological models remain static; the complex contagion does not currently allow agents to dynamically rewire or unfriend neighbors as adoption spreads. Finally, the behavioral propensities mapped from the American Trends Panel fundamentally rely on self-reported survey proxies, inherently carrying potential reporting biases that could influence the absolute values of the evaluated innovation utility thresholds.

6. Conclusion

Ultimately, macroscopic collective outcomes cannot be reduced to the linear aggregate of individual preferences. They are profoundly, and mathematically, dictated by the

multi-dimensional structure of our social ties. By embedding sociologically accurate homophily into diffusion models, we recover the fundamental continuous transitions that characterize empirical society, proving that structural boundaries decide the ultimate trajectory of social change.

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Emergence of Adoption and Phase Transition Signatures

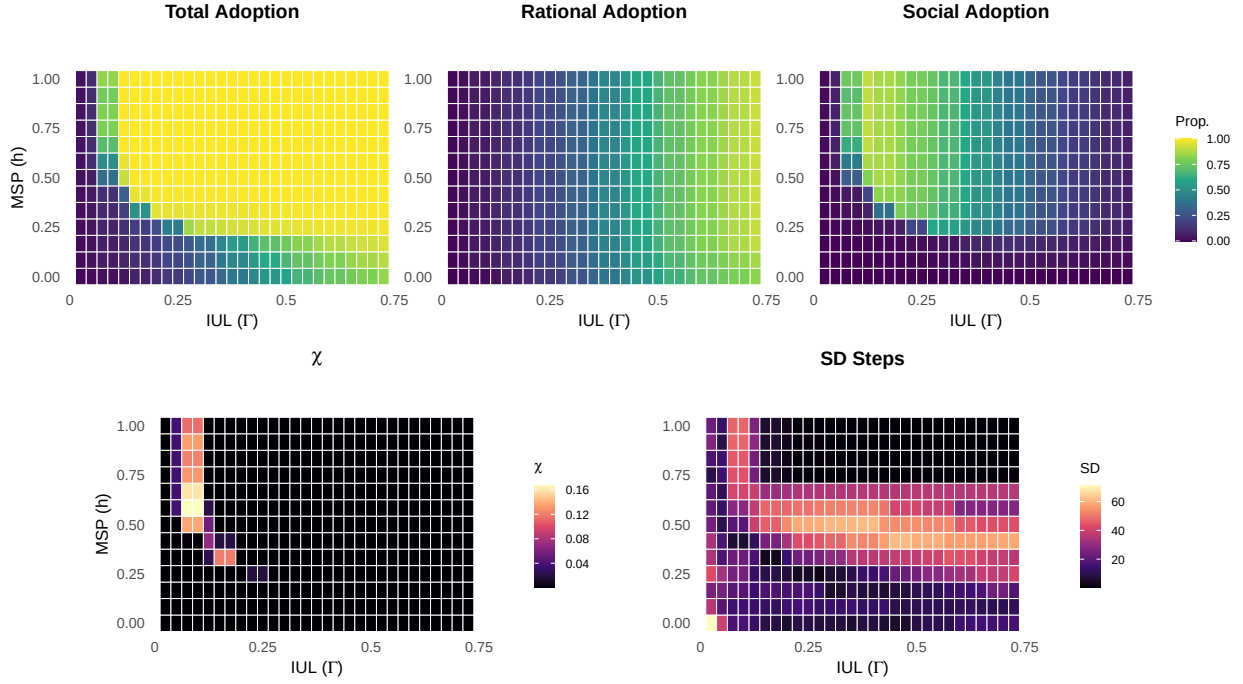


Figure 1: *Adoption Regimes and Phase Transition Signatures*. Top row: Average Total, Rational, and Social Adoption heatmaps. Bottom row (left): Susceptibility $\chi = \text{Var}(\Phi)$ via the Fluctuation-Dissipation Theorem, with the phase boundary visible as a ridge of high variance. Bottom row (right): Standard Deviation of simulation relaxation time; its divergence is the signature of Critical Slowing Down. Simulations based on a GSS plausible network, $\tau_{sd} = 0.12$, and random seeding (see Section S5 for equivalent signatures under Erdős-Rényi topologies).

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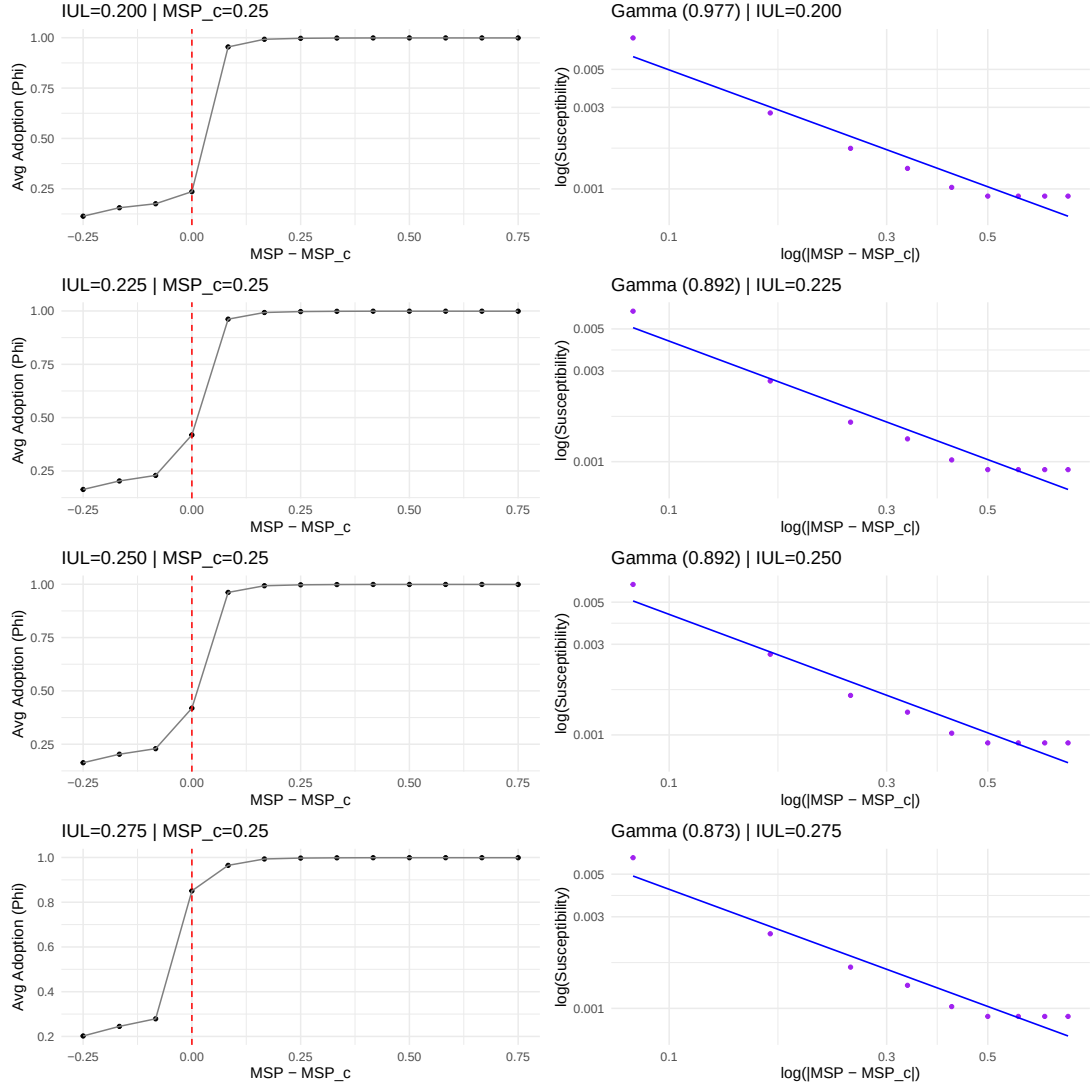


Figure 2: Super-critical susceptibility scaling across the GSS network. The γ exponent extracted from the plausible networks logically converges to ≈ 1 , formally confirming that empirical clustering anchors the complex contagion to a continuous Universality Class. Randomizing the topology invariably disrupts this scaling into unphysical logarithmic cliffs.